

Kayak & Paddle Board Safety Checklist

1. I will plan ahead of time where I am going and will let someone know about my plan.
2. I will give myself more time to return on my trip than when I go out and will not attempt any trip that will be too long for my physical condition.
3. I will plan for unexpected immersion in the water, and understand, it is a good idea to bring extra clothes in a plastic bag, as well as extra drinking water, sunscreen, snacks, sunglasses, a hat, and a safety whistle.
4. I understand I am encouraged to bring some means of communication with me on my trip, such as a cell phone in a plastic bag or portable VHF-FM radio.
5. I understand that it is important to wear shoes while paddling, in case of the need for portaging my vessel.
6. I will make sure that each passenger has a properly-fitted, USCG approved life jacket that is of the proper size for the intended wearer, is in good and serviceable condition (including straps and zippers) and properly stowed.
7. I understand that the U.S Coast Guard recommends that I always wear a lifejacket while underway on a boat.
8. When boarding my vessel, I will stay low, keep my shoulders inside the gunwales, and keep my knees bent, always maintaining three points of contact with the vessel.
9. I will sit only on the seats positioned centrally in the vessel. I understand that sitting on the sides of the vessel may cause it to capsize.
10. In order to prevent capsizing, if a wave is heading in my direction while underway, I understand that the best course of action is to turn the bow of the vessel into the wave so that I don't have to take the wave broadside.
11. I understand the safest way to cross the path of a powerboat is to do so astern or behind the vessel.
12. I will be courteous and mindful of the stopping distances of other vessels.
13. I will carry a whistle or other sound signal on board with me so that I can make appropriate sound signals when needed.

14. I have been made aware of any buoys, markers, and lights I may encounter on my journey and will pay attention to their significance on the water so as to avoid potential hazards.
15. If my vessel tips over, I understand the best course of action is to stay calm, remaining with my vessel (if possible) and then paddle or swim to shore if I am close to the shore with the Vessel downstream from myself.
16. If I cross a channel, I understand the best method is to cross at a right angle to the waterway in order to reduce my time at the crossing.
17. I understand that paddling and alcohol do not mix and that the operation of ANY vessel while intoxicated is dangerous and against, local, state, and federal laws.
18. I also understand that the effects of alcohol while paddling may be increased due to the heat and movement on the water.